a FlexLifeFi K–12 program

GRADE 8 · PARENT GUIDE

What to Watch For at Home

One good question per quarter — no quizzing, no pressure.

Year theme: Measure, Improve, Operate Smarter

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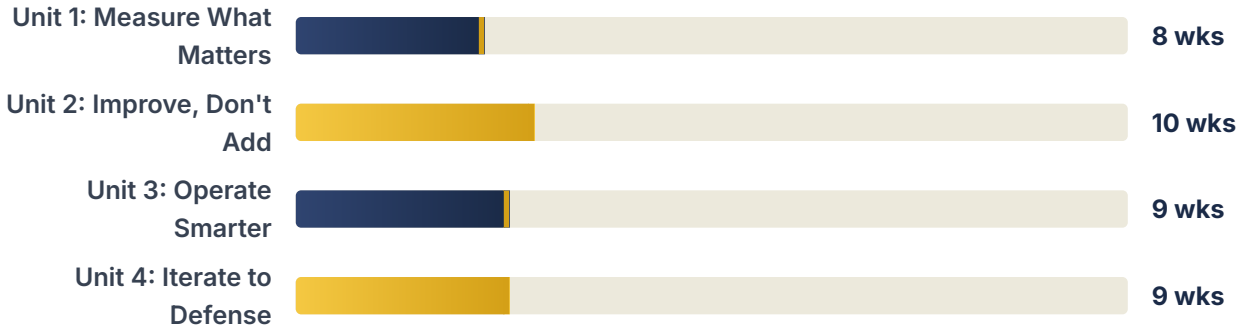
YEAR-AT-A-GLANCE

Four Units. Thirty-Six Weeks. One Capstone.

The year is built as four units, each ending with a public-facing artifact that feeds the rolling Capstone. The bars show how the weeks are spent — roughly equal, with a slight lean toward the math-heavy unit because per-customer math is the load-bearing skill.

WEEKS PER UNIT · GRADE 8



Each unit closes with a checkpoint artifact. Final defense in Week 36.

36 WEEKS

4 UNITS

10 LESSONS

8 CASH VIDEOS

GRADE 8 · PARENT GUIDE

What to Watch For at Home

A little less wrong, every week.

A short, practical guide for the adult who lives with a Grade 8 Cash to Company student.

What this year is

"Don't sell. Show."

— CASH

This year, your student is learning to **operate** a small venture — not by making money, but by running real tests on a small scale and reading what the tests say. The big move of the year is **measure, improve, and operate smarter**: figuring out, with numbers, whether a business idea pays for itself; running short marketing experiments; planning a 4-week sprint; and tracking the gap between what was supposed to happen and what actually did.

If your student took Grade 7 last year, they spent the year learning who their customer is and how much each customer contributes after costs. Grade 8 picks up exactly there. They'll add: a structured way to invent options (called SCAMPER and "How Might We"), a way to compute break-even using 8th-grade linear equations, a 3-day marketing test, a 4-week project plan with a variance column, and a Plan-Do-Study-Act (PDSA) cycle that real businesses use.

Most students do not start a real business this year. The point is not the business. The point is the muscles: invent options on purpose, do the math, run a test, plan a sprint, explain the gap, run another test.

What your student is bringing home

You'll see:

- A **Capstone Journal** — the messy notebook where they sketch, plan, compute, and reflect.
- A **Student Activity Book** — structured worksheets with SCAMPER charts, break-even calculators, sensitivity tables, A/B test tallies, variance trackers, peer-feedback rounds, and reflection prompts.
- Occasional **Cash videos** to watch (2–3 minutes each) — short animated explainers from the program's mascot, Cash.
- Sometimes **two posters** for an A/B test — sometimes asked to be voted on at home or with a neighbor.

- A **break-even calculator** — paper or spreadsheet — with their venture's numbers.

They'll likely talk about their "break-even," "lift," "variance," "PDSA," "sensitivity," and "value lever." If those terms feel new, that's fine — you don't need to know them. Your student will explain.

What you don't need to do

- **You don't need to know any of this.** A parent with no business background can fully support this curriculum.
- **You don't need to fund anything.** Capstones are educational. If your student wants to launch a real venture, that's a family decision and outside the curriculum's expectations.
- **You don't need to share your finances.** Curriculum-wide policy: no student is asked to share family financial details. If your student asks you a money question that feels invasive, redirect them — there's no homework that requires it.

What you can do (if you want)

> *"Tell me what they actually said."*
>
> — CASH

These are optional and low-effort. None are required.

One good question per quarter

Try one of these on a car ride or over dinner:

- **September–October (Unit 1, Ideation):** "What's a SCAMPER prompt you tried this week, and what idea did it produce that you didn't expect?"
- **November–January (Unit 2, Break-even):** "At what number of customers does your venture stop losing money? Show me the math."
- **February–April (Unit 3, Marketing experiment):** "What did your A/B test say, and what couldn't it tell you?"
- **May–June (Unit 4, Operate smarter):** "Where did your plan and reality disagree this week? What did you do about it?"

You don't need to know the right answer. You're modeling curiosity, not expertise.

Be a poster voter (if asked)

Your student may ask you to vote on two posters. The rules: pick the one that makes you more likely to want the product, and tell them honestly why. The most useful thing you can do is not be a cheerleader. Honest feedback beats supportive feedback every time.

Notice variance with them

When something at home doesn't go to plan — a recipe that took longer, a project that came in over budget, a Saturday that didn't match the morning's plan — point it out as variance. Ask: "What was the gap, and what's it telling us?" Modeling that variance is data, not failure, is one of the best home moves you can make in this year of the curriculum.

Share an "operating" story

If you've ever managed a project at work, run a fundraiser, organized a community event, or planned a complex household project — your story is gold. Your student is learning that running something real involves variance, mid-course adjustments, and a "what I'd do differently next time." Your version of that story is more useful to them than a polished case study from a textbook.

Things to watch for

A "great idea" that needs you to spend money

Your student gets excited and wants you to fund supplies. Two responses both work:

- **"What did your math say it would cost? What's break-even?"** (Pulls them into the work.)
- **"This sounds like a real-life version, not a class version. We can talk about whether to do that."** (Separates curriculum from family decision.)

An online venture (Etsy, Instagram, TikTok, YouTube)

Many Grade 8 ventures will be online. The curriculum requires students to write a privacy and safety risk plan in Unit 4. That's a thinking exercise, not permission to launch. Most US platforms have a 13+ minimum age. The school usually has a policy on student-run social accounts. The family is the deciding voice on whether a real account exists. The curriculum supports either choice — hypothetical online venture (full educational value) or real online venture with family approval and supervision.

If your student wants to launch a real online venture, ask three questions before saying yes:

1. **Whose name and information is visible?** (Your student's? Yours? An anonymous handle?)
2. **What's the platform's age requirement, and does my student qualify?**

3. **Who has password access — and how do we close the account if needed?**

If any answer is fuzzy, the right move is "let's keep this hypothetical for the curriculum."

A pricing decision that exposes the family

A student asks you "how much do you spend on lunch?" or similar. The curriculum doesn't require this. Redirect: "for a hypothetical 13-year-old's venture, what do you think most kids would pay for X?" The curriculum uses neutral, hypothetical framing on purpose.

Variance that becomes shame

When a student misses a milestone in their 4-week plan, they sometimes hide it. The curriculum's stance: variance is data. Hidden variance is the failure. If you see your student fudging numbers, gently coach them to write the actual: "the plan said five interviews, the actual was two — what's that telling us?" No moralizing. The teacher will reinforce the same norm.

Real money requests

If your student asks for real money (a $50 supply order, a $25 ad spend), this is a family conversation, not a curriculum requirement. The Capstone can be done entirely on paper. If you're considering a real-money launch, the program's high-school years are the better time for it.

Conversation starters (if you want)

- "Tell me one SCAMPER prompt that pushed you somewhere new."
- "If your contribution margin doubled, what would your break-even look like?"
- "Was anything in your A/B test result hard to look at?"
- "What's the biggest variance in your 4-week plan, and what did you write in the explanation?"
- "What's a privacy risk in your venture you almost missed?"
- "If you ran one more PDSA cycle, what would you change first?"

Privacy and sensitivity

"Most adults skip this. You won't."

— CASH

The curriculum:

- Uses **fictional names** for personas, not classmates' real names.
- Asks students to use **initials only** in interview transcripts and survey writeups.
- Avoids **family financial details** entirely. No homework asks how much your family spends on anything.
- Uses **neutral examples** that don't assume specific home situations.
- Requires a **privacy and safety risk plan** for any venture that touches the internet.

If something feels off, contact the teacher. The teacher can adjust assignments, swap ventures, or modify pacing for any reason — including a flag from a caregiver.

A note about success this year

A "successful" Grade 8 Cash to Company student does not necessarily start a business, make money, or impress a panel. A successful student:

- Generated 10 ideas using a named technique (not just brainstormed).
- Computed a break-even number using linear equations and a sensitivity table.
- Ran a 3-day A/B test with a stated hypothesis and an honest verdict.
- Built a 4-week plan, tracked it, and explained the variance.
- Completed a Plan-Do-Study-Act cycle with a documented change and result.
- Wrote a privacy and safety risk plan with 3-step mitigations.

If you see those things on the kitchen table over the year, the program worked.

Looking ahead to Grade 9

If your student continues with Cash to Company in Grade 9, next year they'll build a full Business Model Canvas (a 9-box venture map), run a customer-discovery cycle with 5 real interviews, model a one-year P&L, and run a 2-week MVP test. Everything they learned in Grade 8 — ideation, break-even, A/B testing, PDSA — feeds directly into next year's work. Strong Grade 8 work makes Grade 9 easier.

Questions?

"Being wrong on Day 1 is the deal."

— CASH

Your student's teacher is the first stop for any question about the curriculum. They can also send home longer-form materials (the full Curriculum Book, the Lesson Plans) if you'd like a deeper look.

Thank you for being part of this. The biggest predictor of whether a financial-thinking habit sticks is whether it's also alive at home — even at the level of one curious question per quarter.

— The Cash to Company team

Senior expert upgrade pack — Weekly "what changed in your test?" prompt

One question per week for the year

You: "What changed in your test this week?"

That's it. Ask it any night. The Grade 8 student is running tests, plans, and PDSA cycles all year. Over the year, this one question gives you a window into:

- **Unit 1 (ideation):** which 3 finalists they picked
- **Unit 2 (break-even):** what their break-even number is and what it told them
- **Unit 3 (A/B test):** which message won and why
- **Unit 4 (PDSA):** what change they tried this week and what they learned

You don't need to know what break-even or PDSA mean. You ask the question. The kid does the thinking.

If your kid is running a real or near-real online business

This is where Grade 8 starts to surface real privacy and safety questions. The curriculum has built-in cases (Etsy at 14, babysitting, Instagram art). If your child is doing any of those for real:

- **Privacy.** Have they shared their address, phone, or last name? Should they?
- **Safety.** Are they meeting strangers from the internet? Always with you?
- **Money.** Is the payment going to your account or theirs? Is there a record?

These are family decisions, not curriculum decisions. The teacher can flag risk; only you can sign off on a real launch. If you're considering a real venture, the high school years are a better time.

ROUND 2 PATCH — Three 30-Second Conversation Starters per Quarter (Grade 8)

Quarter 1 (SCAMPER + How Might We) 1. In a familiar product: "How might we make this better? Substitute, combine, adapt, modify, put to other uses, eliminate, reverse?" — Pick one. — Follow-up: "What would that change?" 2. Drive-time: "Whats a problem in our town? How might we solve it?" — Sample: "Long lines at the DMV. How might we reduce waiting?" 3. At dinner: "Whats a small business you saw today? Whats one SCAMPER move that could improve it?" — Follow-up: "Why that one?"

Quarter 2 (Break-Even + A/B Tests) 1. Drive-time: "If a coffee shop has $1000 fixed costs a month, $1 variable per cup, sells for $5, whats their break-even?" — Sample: "250 cups." — Follow-up: "Whats their daily minimum?" 2. Watching ads: "Were these two ads tested against each other? How would you know which won?" — Follow-up: "What sample size would you need?" 3. In the kitchen: "If we changed our cookie recipe and three friends preferred the new one out of five, is that signal or noise?" — Follow-up: "How many friends would we need?"

Quarter 3 (Project Plan + Variance Write-Up + Weekly Tests)

Weekly prompt: "Whats one test your business ran this week, and what did the numbers tell you?"

- **Sample child response:** "We tried two posters; one got more attention."
- **Follow-up:** "What was the number? How big was the difference? Could it be noise?"

If your child cant answer the number question, the test wasnt measured rigorously. Coach back to the rubric.

Quarter 4 (Privacy + Safety in a Kid-Run Online Business)

If your child sells anything online (Etsy, Depop, Instagram, Discord):

- "Wheres the buyers contact info stored?"
- "Has anyone asked to meet in person?"
- "Has anyone asked you to move the conversation off the platform?"
- "Whats your plan if someone is rude or sketchy?"

These four questions are the privacy/safety baseline. Ask weekly during the unit.

Sensitivity: None of these require the family to share home finances. They work for any family.

ROUND 2 PATCH — What Cash Never Says (Parent Reference)

Cash will never say: "Amazing!" / "Everyone can be rich" / "Easy money" / "Passive income" / "Just believe in yourself" (as substitute for evidence) / anything implying money problems are a personal failing.

Cash always asks: "Which people, and how do you know?" / "Whats the evidence?"

Why this matters at home. Your child will encounter financial-literacy content from many sources, some hustle-bro coded. The contrast is the point. Cash is on your familys side: clear-eyed, honest, never selling.

One question this year: "Did Cash ask you a question this week? What was it?"

ABOUT THE HOST

Cash, in five words

curious · warm · honest · patient · specific

"I'm Cash. I don't promise wealth. I don't promise success. I promise that the moves — interview, math, message, listen — will make you a clearer thinker about money no matter what you end up doing."

— CASH

What Cash does

- **Asks questions that point to evidence.** Cash never tells; Cash asks what your evidence says.
- **Names rules sparingly.** "An assumption is something you think is true without checking. Evidence is something you observed, heard, or counted."
- **Tells short, made-up-but-realistic stories.** 30–60 seconds, shows don't tell.
- **Celebrates the move, not the win.** Revision, honesty, and evidence — not revenue.
- **Hedges deliberately.** probably, often, sometimes — never absolutes about complex topics.

What Cash never does

- Flatter ("amazing!", "great job!"), promise wealth, moralize about money.
- Reference real brands or living celebrities as endorsements.
- Surface family financial details. (Hypothetical scenarios only.)
- Pretend the world is fair. Cash is honest about systemic factors without becoming a politics class.

> *When in doubt, work one of these into the script: Which people, and how do you know? · Being wrong on Day 1 is the deal. · Revenue is loud. Contribution margin is true. · A little less wrong, every week.*

STRAND OUTCOMES

Eight Strands. One Year. Verifiable Outcomes.

Cash to Company runs the same eight strands K-12. Each year deepens the demonstration. The Grade 8 version of each strand is below.

Code	Strand	Grade 8 demonstrated outcome
BAVC	Business Awareness and Value Creation	Identify a business problem, propose a value-creation hypothesis, and revise it with customer evidence.
PSIG	Problem Solving and Idea Generation	Generate, screen, and refine ideas; document why one was chosen and the others were not.
MFL	Money and Financial Literacy	Compute revenue, variable cost, contribution margin, and breakeven for a real product or service.
CBM	Customers, Branding, Marketing	Build a persona from interview evidence; design honest messaging; A/B test two claims.
OSO	Operations, Systems, Organization	Design a simple weekly operating cadence with named roles, handoffs, and a feedback loop.
LTO	Leadership, Teamwork, Ownership	Run and document a team meeting; resolve one disagreement using shared evidence.
ESL	Ethics, Safety, Legal Awareness	Identify the line between persuasion and manipulation; flag one borderline claim and rewrite it honestly.
LRCI	Launch Readiness and Continuous Improvement	Pilot, measure, and document at least three iterations with rationale and what changed.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

Six Benchmarks This Year

Standards are cited at the benchmark level. Honest gaps are named when they exist. The Capstone artifact addresses each one.

Benchmark	What students must demonstrate
Jump$tart 6 (Financial Decision Making) 8-1	Identify the components of decision-making and apply them to financial decisions.
CCSS-Math 8.SP.A.1	Construct and interpret scatter plots for bivariate measurement data.
CCSS-ELA SL.8.4	Present claims and findings, emphasizing salient points in a focused, coherent manner.
C3 D2.Eco.5.6-8	Explain ways in which money facilitates exchange.
CASEL Responsible Decision-Making	Demonstrate curiosity and open-mindedness; analyze information.
CCSS-Math 7.RP.A.3	Use proportional relationships to solve multistep ratio and percent problems.

HOW TO READ THIS TABLE

Each lesson cites at least one of these benchmarks. Each Capstone checkpoint addresses two or more. The Teacher Guide includes a per-lesson standards crosswalk.

"Standards aren't a cage. They're a list of moves you're going to be glad you can make. Pick one. Practice it. Move on."

— CASH

CAPSTONE RUBRIC (4-POINT)

How We Score the Capstone

The Capstone artifact is scored on four traits, each on a 4-point scale. Honest, specific, decision-oriented work earns the high marks. Generic or assumption-laden work earns the low ones.

Trait	1 — Emerging	2 — Developing	3 — Proficient	4 — Advanced
Evidence quality	Mostly assumptions; few or no quotes.	2-3 interview quotes; partial evidence.	5+ direct quotes; varied sources; coded patterns.	Triangulated quotes plus behavioral observation; counter-evidence acknowledged.
Per-customer math	Confused costs; no contribution margin.	CM computed but with errors; one price scenario.	Correct CM and breakeven; clear pricing rationale.	CM under multiple price scenarios; LTV-lite reasoning.
Honest messaging	Vague or misleading claims.	Some specifics; some unsupported claims.	All claims supported; clean ethics check.	A/B-tested copy with rationale; resists clever-but-borderline phrasing.
Feedback system	One-time check; no documentation.	Ad-hoc feedback; partial revisions.	1-week feedback loop with 3 documented changes.	Sustained loop plus signal-vs-noise analysis plus revision log.

CALIBRATION NOTE

Score honestly. A "3" means the student met the standard the way an adult professional would. A "4" means they did something a working entrepreneur would be proud to show. Withhold "4" unless the work earns it.

SENSITIVITY AND FAMILY ENGAGEMENT

What We Don't Ask. What We Always Frame.

Money is a tool, not a virtue. Some students live in households with credit-card debt, low or no banking access, or active financial stress. The curriculum is built so that none of those students is asked to disclose, perform, or apologize for their family situation.

Rules of the room

- **Never ask about family money.** No questions about parents income, debts, accounts, or banking status.
- **Use neutral hypotheticals.** "For a sample family with a $4,000/month take-home" — not "your family."
- **Decouple wealth from worth.** Cash never says "everyone can be rich." Cash says "you will be a clearer thinker about money no matter what you end up doing."
- **Name systemic factors honestly.** Wage gaps, geography, and luck shape outcomes. The skill we build is the skill in the student hands.
- **Protect the venture.** A student Capstone is theirs. We don't require they share revenue or family contribution. The artifact is the work, not the bank account.

Family engagement

Parents get one well-framed question per quarter — never a quiz, never a money-disclosure prompt. The default frame is curiosity ("What did you notice about your customers this week?"), not interrogation ("How much did you make?").

"Money is a tool. The question is not whether your family has a lot of it. The question is what you do with the moves we are practicing — interview, math, message, listen — wherever your starting line happens to be."

— CASH

ACTIVITY INDEX

Ten Activities. One Notebook.

Every activity in this book is built to be done with a pencil, your own evidence, and the questions Cash keeps asking. Skip nothing. Date everything. Re-read in three months.

No.	Activity	What you will do
01	Day 1 Customer Assumption	One sentence, one card. Don't try to be right; try to be specific.
02	Open vs. Leading Questions	Rewrite five leading questions into open ones. Practice on a partner.
03	Coding Patterns from Transcripts	Highlight surprises, frustrations, wishes. Tally them. Find the pattern.
04	Persona Pack v1	Combine evidence into one specific person — name, behaviors, top frustration.
05	Variable Cost per Unit	From a real receipt, compute the cost per one of the thing you sell.
06	Contribution Margin Worksheet	Price minus variable cost. Decide if it covers your fixed costs.
07	Two-Message A/B Test	Two honest messages. Three-day test. Report the winner and why.
08	Persuasion vs. Manipulation Line	Sort 10 ad claims onto a line. Defend your placement.
09	1-Week Feedback Loop	Collect, code, and act on feedback. Document three changes.
10	Final Capstone Defense	Five slides. Five minutes. Show the moves you made.

NOTEBOOK SETUP

Get a single notebook for the whole year. Number every page. The first 5 pages are your Vocabulary Spine. The last 5 pages are your Day-1 Assumptions (you will come back to those). Everything in between is your work.

Notebook checklist

- **Title page** — your name, your venture working-title, today's date.
- **Vocabulary spine** — 5 pages reserved for definitions you will add as we go.
-

Customer notes — one section for interview transcripts. Use direct quotes, with initials and dates.

- **Math section** — receipts taped in, per-unit computations, contribution margin scratch work.
- **Messaging section** — drafts of two-claim A/B tests, with what won and why.
- **Feedback log** — one page per week of your feedback system, with the three changes you made.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked Example: Measure What Matters

Priya runs a tutoring micro-business helping 6th graders with pre-algebra. She has eight regular clients. Five say they would recommend her. Three would not. Her old metric was "hours billed." Her new metric: "would recommend."

The new metric tells a different story. Two of her three non-recommenders share the same complaint: "Sessions feel like quizzes." Priya redesigns the first 10 minutes of every session to start with what the student is stuck on, not what Priya wants to teach. Three weeks later: 7 of 8 would recommend.

What changed? Not effort. Not skill. The metric. "Would recommend" surfaced the experience. Hours billed surfaced nothing.

WHAT TO COPY

The move here is not the answer. It is the structure: specific number, specific person, specific decision. Use that pattern in your own venture this quarter.

> *"Most adults skip this. You won't. Pick one customer. Compute one number. Decide one thing." — Cash*

END-OF-QUARTER REFLECTION

Four Quarters. Same Five Questions.

At the end of every quarter you will answer the same five questions. The answers should look different over time. Reread the previous quarter before you write a new one.

1. **Which people did you talk to this quarter, and what did they actually say?**

   Specific quotes, initials, dates. Resist the urge to summarize.
2. **What did you change in your venture because of evidence?**

   Name the change. Name the evidence that caused it.
3. **What is one number you know better now than three months ago?**

   Variable cost per unit. Contribution margin. Anything quantitative.
4. **What is a claim you made that you would take back?**

   Be honest. The claim does not have to be public. The honesty is the move.
5. **What would Cash ask you about all of this?**

   "Which people, and how do you know?" is always available. Find your own version.

> *"Reflection is not a feeling check-in. It is a memory tool. The you in three months wants to know what the you today learned. Write it down so future-you can use it."*
>
> — CASH

One promise.

Cash to Company makes one promise: students who move through this program will be clearer thinkers about money and entrepreneurship — no matter what they end up doing for a living.

We do not promise wealth. We do not promise success. We promise clarity.

"A little less wrong, every week."

— CASH, GRADE 8